At Depayin, the ultimate clash would ensue. Well-armed USDA forces and members of the military ambushed Suu Kyi's entourage. This attack was carefully orchestrated and planned. Nearly a week prior to the attack, Lieutenant Colonel Than Han had gathered local USDA members to the campus of Depayin High School. Several days of training ensued in preparation for the assault. The assailants were armed with bamboo staves, baseball bats, and sharpened iron rods, many of the weapons prepared by a local blacksmith. Years later it was confirmed that this event was indeed meant to culminate in the assassination of Aung San Suu Kyi. It is estimated that close to 5,000 pro-government forces were in place for what turned out to be a massacre. It was labeled “Black Friday” and over 70 people were beaten to death and over 100 injured. Witnesses later claimed that the attackers seemed to be drunk or on drugs during the carnage. No mercy was shown even to women and children, who were beaten as well. The evidence was quickly removed as police quickly began arresting suspected sympathizers. Former secretary of the USDA U Win Sein later stated that Than Shwe had stated that the attack was meant to “get rid of” and “exterminate” Suu Kyi. When members of the security forces present at the meeting questioned the meaning of the statements, Shwe supposedly replied, “We must exterminate her.” Within hours, Suu Kyi and other leaders of the NLD were once again arrested.

A committee investigating the Depayin massacre, cochaired by U Khin Kyaw Han, a member of parliament from the NLD, stated that no such coordinated attack could have taken place without the total backing and planning of the security and military apparatus in Myanmar. Several eyewitness accounts have confirmed Than Shwe's precise role in the attempted assassination.

What makes the Depayin massacre so heroic is that throughout the carnage the NLD and Aung San Suu Kyi's supporters stood steadfast in their nonviolent approach. As supporters were beaten mercilessly, they surrounded Suu Kyi in layers to attempt to protect her from the mob violence. The split-second decision of her driver to speed up as the windows of her car were being broken as well as his decision to drive through the roadblock setup by the military inevitably saved her life.

As has been the case for decades, the military regime attempted to ignore the international outcry. This was difficult as new sanctions were